ANALYST INSTITUTE

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State Ecosystem Framework

A Tool for Understanding a State's Multiracial Pro-Democracy Ecosystem

Introduction

In 2024, Democracy Fund partnered with Analyst Institute to produce a comprehensive framework to assess the health of individual states' multiracial pro-democracy ecosystems,[1] providing stakeholders with tools to identify strengths, address gaps, and guide strategic investments in service of building a stronger, more inclusive, multiracial democracy.

Developed using an extensive review of power-building and civic engagement literature[2] and interviews with researchers and state organizers, this framework advances the broader community's understanding of multiracial power-building and adapts it to the unique dynamics of state-level ecosystems. By focusing on a discrete set of collective capacities and operating environment factors relevant across states, it offers the potential for impact at the state level and cross-state learning, as it enables consistent but flexible evaluation, meaningful investments, and applied scholarship across states.

Framework

The framework identifies nine attributes that shape an ecosystem's overall status. Some of these attributes describe conditions that shape the operating environment for the entire ecosystem. Other attributes refer to the collective capacities of, and dynamics within, the organizations that comprise the ecosystem. At the heart of the framework are the organizing

[1] In the context of movement-building, an *ecosystem* comprises the organizations working within a state and the ways that they interact with one another and the broader political and social environment. Pro-democracy organizing occurs across many interrelated but distinct ecosystems; this framework specifically focuses on organizations whose work includes building political power through civic engagement and related activities.

[2] While this work drew on many sources, it primarily built on the University of Southern California Equity Research Institute's report Changing States: A Framework for Progressive Governance (Pastor, Ito, and Wander, 2016).

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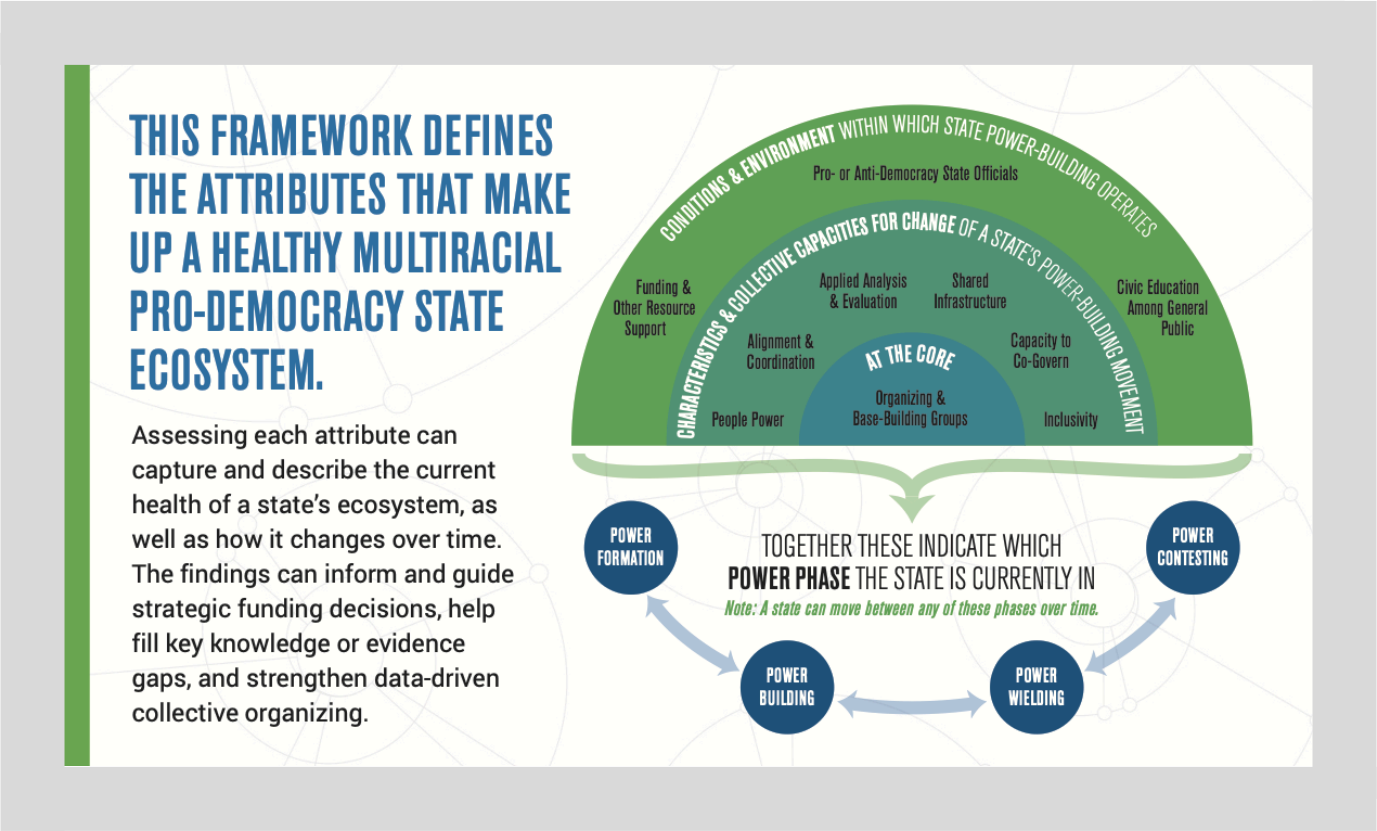
groups and individuals who drive power-building efforts, emphasizing that people are the core agents of systemic change.

Figure 1. The State Ecosystem Framework identifies nine attributes that collectively describe the strength of a state's pro-democracy ecosystem.[3]



The external dimension, *Conditions and Environment*, examines the broader context within which power-building efforts operate, including 1) Funding and Other Resource Support, 2) Pro- or Anti-Democracy State Officials, and 3) Civic Education among the General Public. The internal dimension, *Characteristics and Collective Capacities for Change*, focuses on the collective strength of a state's power-building movement, investigated through 4) People Power, 5) Alignment and Coordination, 6) Applied Analysis and Evaluation, 7) Shared Infrastructure, 8) Capacity to Co-Govern, and 9) Inclusivity. (All attributes are defined in Table 1.)

[3] A complete image description is available in the appendix.

Table 1. The State Ecosystem Framework – Attribute Descriptions

Level	Attribute	Description
Conditions and Environment	Funding and other resource support	The impact of foundations and donors on movement-building in the state.
	Pro- or anti-democracy state officials	How political officials across state/local government branches or offices work to promote or suppress democracy.
	Civic education among the general public	Understanding of, and trust in, democracy and civic participation among the general public.
Characteristics and Collective Capacities for Change	People power	Skills and capacities present in the ecosystem, as well as systems for upskilling, retaining, and supporting talent at all levels.
	Alignment and coordination	Coalition-building and general collaboration among pro-democracy groups.
	Applied analysis and evaluation	How organizing groups apply the findings of ecosystem studies, impact assessments, and other kinds of research and use data to improve strategies.
	Shared infrastructure	Systems for sharing operations needs (such as compliance, finance, data, HR, security, legal support, etc.) among organizing groups.
	Capacity to co-govern	The use of co-governing structures (such as participatory budgeting, community advisory councils, etc.).
	Inclusivity	How organizing groups collectively reflect and serve marginalized communities in the state.

Structuring the framework through these two system-level dimensions helps place states within one of four power phases—formation, building, wielding, and contesting—based on their current ecosystem dynamics. The power phases (defined in *Table 2*) are anchored around the

collective movement's ability to shape the state's governing agenda. These phases are nonlinear, with states moving between them as conditions evolve.

Table 2. State ecosystems can be categorized among four power phases.

Phase of Power	Defining Features
Power formation	Constituencies are establishing organized groups, typically clustered within urban centers.
Power building	Organizations are maturing and bases are expanding (including in rural areas), eventually achieving cross-state coordination.
Power wielding	Beginning after key electoral wins, politicians and the movement are collaborating to enact and implement majority-driven policies and programs at the state level.
Power contesting	Beginning when electoral losses occur after a power wielding phase, organizations are taking collective action to regain strategic momentum and positions of authority. This phase acknowledges that organizations can grow their collective capacities in a positive direction even when they are facing backsliding, backlash, or difficult barriers in their environmental conditions.

Conclusion

Utilizing the framework, funders can invest in long-term change guided by the experiences of organizations on the ground. The framework offers a shared language to discuss and understand state ecosystems, fostering collaboration among funders, organizers, and evaluators. It also provides stakeholders with tools to make strategic investments and monitor ecosystem health and shifting needs over time. By focusing on system-level rather than organization-level characteristics, the framework helps stakeholders identify structural gaps and opportunities for collective impact.

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Appendix

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- **Anonymous** (Minnesota)

In addition, we are grateful for the time and intellectual leadership provided to this project by former Analyst Institute staff members Heather Hicks and Tricia Petruney, whose work shaped the development of the framework.

Image Description for Figure 1

On the left side of the image, text reads as follows: “This framework defines the attributes that make up a healthy multiracial pro-democracy state ecosystem. Assessing each attribute can capture and describe the current health of a state’s ecosystem, as well as how it changes over time. The findings can inform and guide strategic funding decisions, help fill key knowledge or evidence gaps, and strengthen data-driven collective organizing.”

On the right side of the image, a semicircle represents the dimensions of a state’s pro-democracy ecosystem. The semicircle has three layers that visually distinguish among these dimensions.

The outer layer shows the attributes comprising the first dimension, “Conditions and environment within which state power-building operates.” The attributes included in this

dimension are Pro- or Anti-Democracy State Officials, Funding & Other Resource Support, and Civic Education Among General Public.

The middle layer shows the attributes comprising the second dimension, "Characteristics & collective capacities for change of a state's power-building movement." The attributes included in this dimension are People Power, Alignment & Coordination, Applied Analysis & Evaluation, Shared Infrastructure, Capacity to Co-Govern, and Inclusivity.

The innermost layer reads, "At the Core: Organizing & Base-building Groups."

A bracket below the semicircle connects these dimensions to the power phase spectrum, with text reading: "Together these indicate which power phase the state is currently in. Note: a state can move between any of these phases over time." The four power phases—Power formation, Power building, Power wielding, and Power contesting—are connected by bidirectional arrows.

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